



THE CAUSE of the fire is being investigated, though the mayor’s office has tied it to a homeless encampment.

Tunnel fire shuts down I10 at Port of L.A.

Northbound lanes are closed indefinitely. Items in encampment may be acting as fuel.

By CIERRA MORGAN AND FEDOR ZARKHIN

An underground fire burning in what appeared to be an encampment shut down a major Los Angeles freeway for hours as officials worked to determine the level of damage to the frequently used route to the L.A. port complex.

Southbound I10 Freeway lanes in San Pedro were closed for hours Tuesday morning, and northbound lanes out of the port are closed indefinitely.

“This is a deep-seated, stubborn fire,” Los Angeles Fire Capt. Tony Tubbs said. “So it’s going to be a prolonged incident.”

It’s unclear what started the fire in the tunnel near West Harry Bridges Boulevard, but Los Angeles Fire Department officials said its location deep inside a 150-to-200-foot tunnel with an opening that’s only 4 feet by 4 feet posed a significant challenge. The tunnel is packed with wood, mattresses and other items common to homeless encampments that could burn, officials said.

Mayor Karen Bass’ office tied the fire to the city’s chronic homelessness issues.

“While the exact cause is still being investigated, this illustrates why Mayor Bass is determined to end street homelessness, which is often the cause of fires,” the office said in a statement. “We are grateful for the L.A. firefighters and first responders who have now confined the fire.”

[See Fire, A10]

Gridlock grips Yosemite after end to reservations

People face long lines even before summer crush

By Jack Dolan

People heading to Yosemite to escape urban congestion fumed over the weekend as they waited in a seemingly endless line of cars at the park entrance.

Inside, they circled aimlessly around full parking lots, scanning for empty spots instead of majestic views.

Near the summit of Half Dome, on the infamous steel cables hikers use to ascend the final stretch of bare granite, another traffic jam formed, trapping people hundreds of feet in the air, according to social media posts.

Even before the summer rush, California’s most visited national park is seeing big crowds — the most people in a decade, according to National Park System data.

Critics of the free-for-all are blaming the influx on the Trump administration for abandoning a reservation requirement that, for the last few years, has helped control the number of visitors and preserve a sense of natural tranquility.

California’s nine national parks drew a record 12 million visitors in 2025, up more than 800,000 from the previous record set in 2019. Yosemite accounted for more than a quarter of those visits.

This year, the pace continues, with more than half a million visits to Yosemite so far. In March, the park recorded 236,000 visits, up more than 45% from the same month a year earlier.

Yosemite National Park is enormous, covering more than 1,100 square miles on the western slope of the Sierra Nevada mountain range. Even at the height of summer, an adventurous soul willing to hike a bit can spend weeks in the park and rarely see another person.

But Yosemite’s most famous and Instagrammable vistas — the towering, 3,000-foot granite wall of El Capitan, the thundering spectacles of Yosemite and Bridalveil falls — can be enjoyed from parking

[See Yosemite, A7]

BURNEY FALLS: Passes are now required for crowd control. CALIFORNIA, B1

Tom Steyer tries to sell voters on his own personal change

By BEN WIEDER AND HAYLEY SMITH

Tom Steyer is trying to sell himself to voters as an agent of change.

He has vowed to take on entrenched political and economic forces to create affordable housing, make the wealthy pay more in taxes, lower energy bills and protect the environment.

But perhaps the biggest change he is selling is his own.

The hedge-fund billionaire turned climate activist has faced criticism throughout his campaign for past investments in coal plants and private prisons, to name

a few, that helped build his fortune and gave him the means to spend more than \$150 million of his own money in his quest for the governor’s mansion.

Steyer’s prolific spending has blanketed the airwaves with television ads and helped propel him near the top of an unsettled gubernatorial field in the polls.

The 68-year-old San Franciscan has helped put many Democratic candidates in office as one of the party’s biggest political donors in the last two decades but has never held public office himself.

He spent more than \$340 million in the 2020 Democratic presidential pri-

mary but dropped out after placing third in the primary in South Carolina, where he had invested heavily.

There is a long tradition of wealthy, self-funding candidates, and the results are mixed at best. Billionaire Michael Bloomberg spent more than \$260 million to win three terms as New York City mayor. But he spent more than \$1 billion on a 2020 presidential bid and lasted only four days longer in the race than Steyer. Two years later, real estate developer Rick Caruso spent more than \$100 million in an effort to become Los Angeles mayor but lost handily to Karen Bass.

[See Steyer, A7]

GOVERNOR DEBATE: Get our coverage of the latest faceoff at latimes.com.

Injured L.A. ‘No Kings’ protesters seek justice

By SUMMER LIN

Micah Moore, a film production assistant, recently underwent his second surgery to restore the hearing in his right ear after being shot in the head with a rubber bullet while attending the “No Kings” protest in downtown Los Angeles last June.

“It really completely flipped huge parts of my life upside down,” the 25-year-old told The Times. “It’s been very disabling at work, with friends, with family — a lot of sleepless nights.”



TUCKER COLLINS, an 18-year-old USC student, was blinded in one eye by a “less-lethal projectile.”

During a similar protest rally in March, Tucker Collins, an 18-year-old USC student, was blinded in one eye after being shot with a “less-lethal projectile” that struck him in the face.

Both young men are now seeking justice for their injuries, with Moore filing a lawsuit against the Los Angeles Police Department and the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department because he hasn’t identified the agency responsible for his injury. Collins filed a federal claim last month against the U.S. Department of Justice.

[See Injuries, A11]

U.S. shifts from offense to hope of an Iran deal

Rubio says Operation Epic Fury ‘is over,’ a step toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

By ANA CEBALLOS, NABIH BULOS AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The U.S. military campaign that launched the war with Iran, Operation Epic Fury, “is over,” Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Tuesday, telling reporters that a new defensive phase had begun to secure the Strait of Hormuz — though President Trump later said he was pausing the effort to allow more time for a deal with Iran.

The declaration of an end to offensive operations comes as Trump continues to threaten a new round of strikes against the Islamic Republic, which persists in disrupting commercial shipping traffic through the vital waterway.

But Rubio, who is also the national security adviser,

suggested the Trump administration is reluctant to return to full-scale war.

“The operation, Epic Fury, is concluded. We achieved the objectives of that operation,” Rubio said at a news briefing at the White House.

“This is the first step toward reopening the strait,” he added. “We are doing it not only because we were asked, but because we are the only ones that can.”

Trump said Tuesday night on Truth Social that Project Freedom — the new defensive operation — would be paused for a “short period of time” at the request of Pakistan and other countries “to see whether or not” a final agreement can be reached with Iran.

The shift came within hours of top administration officials touting the new initiative as a needed step to ensure the flow of traffic could resume through the international waterway as hostilities have continued in the region.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth had told reporters

[See Iran, A4]

Feds target LAUSD over sex allegations

Agency investigates ‘reassignment’ of teachers. District says policy misinterpreted.

By HOWARD BLUME

The U.S. Department of Education is investigating the Los Angeles school district for allegedly reassigning — rather than removing — teachers who have been accused of sexual misconduct, including those who have had “romantic relationships” with students.

The department alleges that the district, under terms “cemented” in its contract with the teachers union, “appears to guarantee that teachers will be reassigned, not terminated or immediately removed from student facing roles, while officials investigate” accusations made against instructors.

The federal interpretation of alleged wrongdoing appears to be based on the meaning of the word “reassignment.” The federal agency seems to presume

that reassignment means an accused teacher has a contractual right to teach at a different school. If that’s the case, the L.A. Unified policy would be illegal under federal law, the department contends.

The district, however, said it defines reassignment differently. Any “insinuating” that the school system assigns those under investigation to other schools “is not true,” the district said in a statement released after the federal announcement. “Confusion seems to center on the meaning of the term ‘reassignment.’ ‘Reassignment’ typically means an employee is directed to remain at home and away from students and schools during an investigation.”

Although education jargon can be confusing, the district’s use of the word “reassignment” is in line with other public school districts.

The LAUSD policy states that “a reassignment is defined as the provisional removal of an employee from their regularly assigned workplace for the safety of District students, staff, or

[See LAUSD, A10]



MATTHEW MURPHY

TONY NOMINEES

Nicholas Christopher gets a nod for “Chess,” above, as Lea Michele is shut out. “Lost Boys,” “Schmigadoon!” lead noms. ENTERTAINMENT, B1

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The school receives \$200 million, one of its largest gifts ever, to expand its work in the field. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 74/56. B5

Markets A14 Opinion Voices A16

Lakers-Thunder meet in Game 1

Western Conference series tips off. For full coverage, go to latimes.com/lakers. For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



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